LAF YOMI

Bekhorot 39 · October 27, 2026

ON TODAY'S DAF

Bekhorot 39: the tail of the eye-blemish grain test (moist then dry, tied or untied, alone or with friends, city or field), Pinchas's retroactivity question and Shmuel's 'the lame capture the spoils,' the nose-and-lip blemish catalogue, and the internal-defect sugya — one kidney, three kidneys, the animal with no heart, and hours that disqualify kodashim.

קשור או מותר · THE GEMARA'S DIAGNOSTIC SPA DAY



1. To test whether a tearing eye is a permanent blemish, the animal must eat a fig-bulk of grain — and the Gemara interrogates the lab conditions: tied or untied? Alone or with company? City or field?

“Untied — certainly effective, it feels good. With friends — certainly better. In the field — certainly best, out in the open air. (A garden near the city? Teiku.)”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 39a · קשור או מותר — tied or untied, alone or with friends, city or field · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 11:15

בעיר או בשדה · THE USED-COW LEMON LAW



2. The poskim apply this Gemara to a very modern problem: you sold me a cow, promising she gives a certain number of gallons of milk a day — and now she gives nowhere near that.

“You can't claim mekach ta'ut — our Gemara proves how much environment and circumstance change an animal's output. Maybe it's your barn that dried her up, not my cow.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 39a · בעיר או בשדה — the field-vs-city test, and what it does to a cow's milk · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 12:47

פיסחים בזזו בז · SHMUEL'S BACKHANDED COMPLIMENT



3. Pinchas, Shmuel's brother, asks a geshmake question: if the 80-day test proves the blemish, was it a mum all along, or only from day 80? Shmuel answers with a verse.

“פיסחים בזזו בז — the lame capture the most spoils.' You're not such a great talmid chacham — but what a question! And the mefarshim add: the 'lame' ones, the baalei mum, have a power the healthy lack — they can be redeemed.”

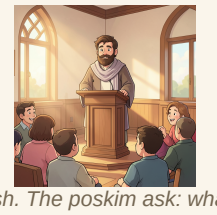
— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 39a · קרי שמואל עלוי — 'the lame capture the most spoils' · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 23:03

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חוטמו שניקב · THE BAAL TESHUVAH CHAZZAN



4. The mishnah says a pierced nose is a blemish. The poskim ask: what about a man who used to wear a nose ring and, baruch Hashem, became a baal teshuvah? Can he be baal tefillah, when lechatchilah a baal mum shouldn't lead davening?

“Some poskim are machmir — but others say: this Gemara is about animals. A hole you made for decoration doesn't make a person a baal mum.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 39a · ניקבו חוטמין זה לתוך זה — the pierced nostril, and the nose-ring question · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 25:14

יש בריה באחת · THE ANIMAL WITH NO HEART



5. Can a creature be born with just one kidney? The Chazon Ish notes how hard it is to argue about metziut — and Elefant brings the famous machloket acharonim.

“An animal was slaughtered and found to have no heart at all. Some poskim said: impossible — it must have had a heart and it fell out, so the animal is kosher!”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 39a · יש בריה באחת — can a creature be born with one kidney? · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 35:08

שעות פוסלות בקדשים · THE BAR-MITZVAH BOY'S SECOND TEFILLIN



6. By kodashim, hours — not days — decide: an animal that turns one year old at 10 o'clock is fine at 9 and too old at 10. Some opinions apply the same hour-rule to a bar mitzvah.

“Born at 12 o'clock? You're only bar mitzvah at 12 o'clock. So Rav Moshe Sternbuch says: put tefillin on again at noon — until 12 you were a katan, now you're a gadol!”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 39b · שעות פוסלות בקדשים — hours disqualify (or qualify) kodashim · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 43:20